



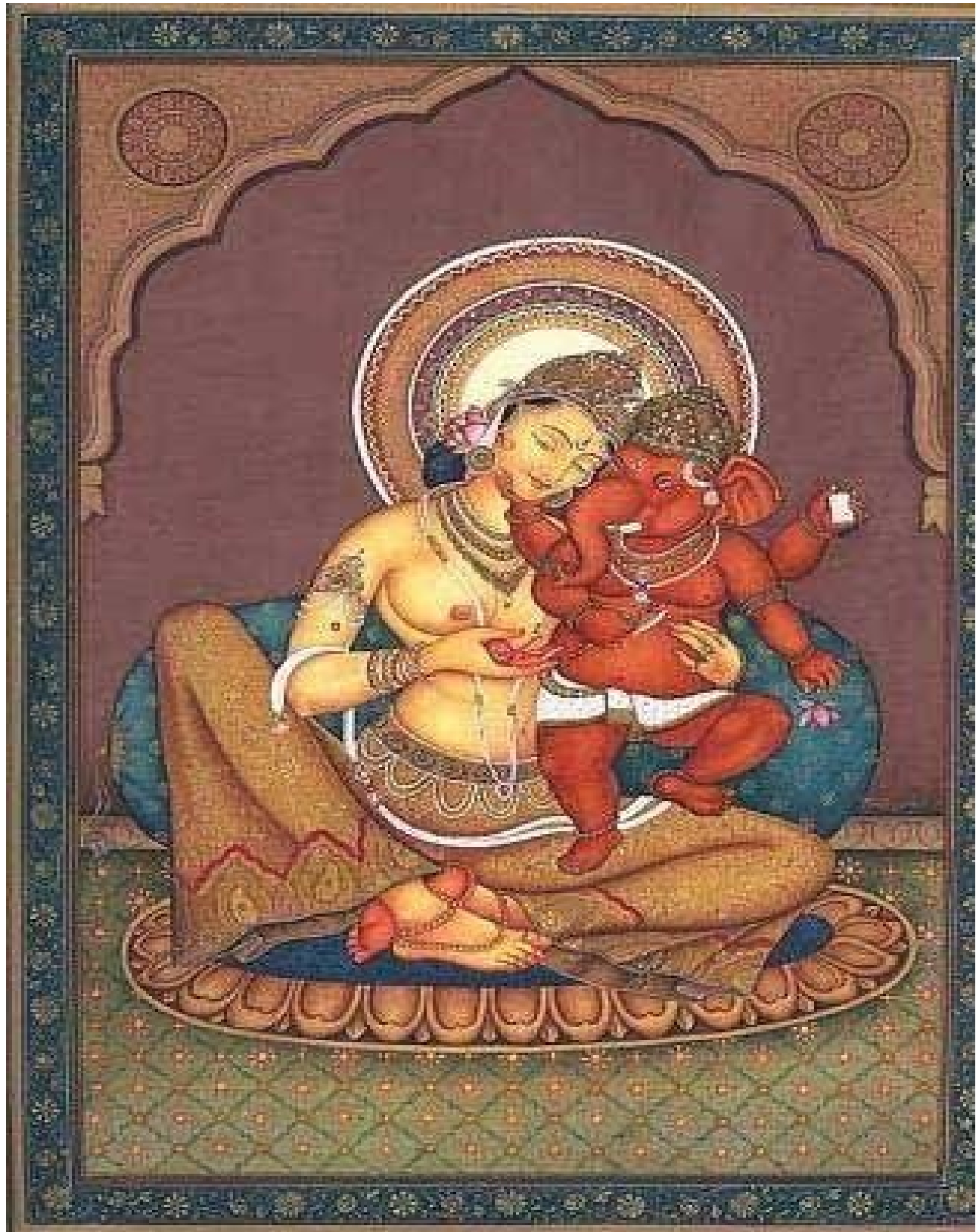
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Editorial



From the Chief Editor's Desk

The notion of an expanse of infinity as Shankar's Spandashakti -

As the indistinguishable prowess of gnosis of the absolute principle para Shiva - She has been conceived of as the deity of gnosis which in this parlance refers to the infinite sphuratta or the spontaneous manifestation. which is at the same time also an Incessant and eternally awakened prowess of the mantra i.e., "aham" the pure subjective awareness. Which abbreviates in itself the entire expanse of the Sanskrit alphabet. A Semitic notion of God that word was there at the beginning and the word was the God. sounds similar but doesn't fall in with the word and meaning unison theory and cannot be relevant when it comes to explaining the mode and process of creation in an oriental way especially according to the agamas. The absolute infinite god contains the relatively infinite creation within the domain of his infinity. Thus the propitiatory verse of the Spanda Karika refers to the infinite Sphuratta or creative out-flux is Anant sphuratta. The ultimate mantra is the subjective first-person pronoun "I" the Sanskrit for this is aham and mystically though, it has all alphabets and their all possible combinations abbreviated in it. This school of thought which promotes the alphabetic word transcendence for emancipation predates the mystic hermits or Hesychast sect. Their traces are still present in some desolate and arcane cloisters of the eastern or Greek Orthodox Church. They stop psalmodising after they have done it strenuously for years and years together. That is to say that they do not even psalmodies anymore; the mystic process must have been something similar to its oriental counterpart. Shabdraashhi ant poorna is full of all the gamut of spoken expressible or conceived words.

The aspirant should withdraw his senses from their objects, with his intellect retrained with patience. After the mind is seated in the essential nature, stop all thoughts. -the Gita.

This last part of the verse "stop thinking" is strived at by various sects in various ways eastern or western. All hesychastic techniques have been laboriously guarded and propagated through an uninterrupted lineage of preceptors. Reversing the order of creation of word and meaning or name and form can lead to an absolute absorption into the substratum of the universal phenomena which is a transcendental principle. The order of extension and tracing the way back to the source is a highly arcane and esoteric procedure and may conflict with the norms of institutionalized religion. The mystics of this lineage have always bowed out from the discipline of ecclesiastic submission. Be-shar as they are called in Sufi traditions are exempt from the injunctions of Shariat in case they come in the way of their pursuit of marifat or -the metaphysical truth. The Gita says - that even an enquirer of yoga transcends the discipline of the revelations. The popular exclamation hant! of classical Sanskrit shows how wonderstruck the author of this compendium must

have been while disclosing this great arcane cult which surpasses conditioning of the testimony of scriptural evidence and instead leads the aspirant to a rapport with the source of all revelations. They termed it samapatti or assimilation in the trika doctrine. Though complete, she manifests herself as the image of the entire universal phenomena in the mirror of clear consciousness as the substratum. The image emerges as the conglomerate of the universe consisting of thirty-six elementary Constituents of the Universal phenomena. There are various popular notions of - the creator and creation relationship in the orient as well as occident. These can be categorized into four groups: creator as the creation, creator as different from creation and creator as creation and pervading it, and the creator as a transcendental principle. This is ruling out the theories where there is no concept of any god as creator including the schools of thought which maintain the transitory or virtual nature of the creation of creation. Sphuratta vada as some thinkers have called the philosophy of spanda is akin to the theory of pre-shankarite ajatvada or the "momentary gnosis" theory of Buddhism. The completeness and subjective and objective categories. There is a mention of one Audulomi acharya who propounded a similar theory-that the whole universal phenomena with all names and forms were only subjective consciousness in its essential form. *

*Owing to the opinions the self is perfectly homogeneous like a lump of saindhava salt neither within nor without but consolidated taste i.e., salty. In The same manner the self-consolidates consciousness with no other heterogeneity within or without.

By the statement "only consolidate consciousness or *vijnanaghana*"- Audulomi acharya has postulated that everything is pervaded by the essential nature wing to the similar nature of the pervaded and the pervader. [commentary of shrikanthacharya] BS 4.4.

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The Himalayas: A Mystic's Viewpoint

[Paranand Swami]

The word *Himalaya* means 'the abode of snow'. Apart from being a geographical entity, it has in various ways shaped the life and culture of the South Asian people. Comprising the nine highest peaks in the world, this awe-inspiring range has been an object of veneration for people and epitomizes the concept of sublime beauty.

The Himalayas are bordered on the north by the Tibetan Plateau, on the south by the Indo-Gangetic Plain, on the northwest by the Karakoram and the Hindu Kush ranges, and on the east by the Indian states of Assam and Arunachal Pradesh. The Himalayas span five countries: India, Nepal, Bhutan, China (Tibet), and Pakistan with the first three countries having dominion over most of the range.

The Himalayas are home to three major Indian rivers which are the lifeline of the area—the Indus, the Ganges, and the Brahmaputra. Important civilizations arose at the bank of these magnanimous rivers; hence, they occupy a very special place in the hearts of the people who consider them as their mother. While the Indus and the Brahmaputra rise near Mount Kailash in Tibet, the Ganges rise in the Indian state of Uttarakhand.

In the Hindu tradition and belief system, the Himalayas are not only a magnificent mountain range but also the sacred abode of the gods. In various texts, the range itself is considered as the manifestation of the divine and often referred to as *devatma* or God-souled.

Also known as *Giriraj* or the 'King of Mountains', they assume a significant position in Hindu myths, folklore, and history. The earliest text mentioning the Himalayas is the Rig Veda. Singing the praise of the supreme deity, the poet-sage refers to the Himalaya: "It is to Him to whom belong these celestial mountain ranges". These sages also describe its stretch as "the expanse of the two arms of the great being". The epics *Ramayana* and *Mahabharata*, and the *Puranas*, describe this as the region where the gods dwell, and the landscape is evoked beautifully in classical poetical works. According to the *Skanda Purana*, "As the sun dries the morning dew so does the mere sight of the Himalaya dissipate the sins of man".

The Himalayan range as a whole is sacred because it is in the north, which for Hindus is the direction of wisdom and spiritual rebirth. It also includes the highest peaks in the world, which are a sight to inspire awe and wonder in people of any race or creed. From times immemorial, the Himalayas have given out speechless invitations to sages, anchorites, yogis, artists, and philosophers. The mighty altitude of the Himalayas constantly reminds us of the loftiness of the human soul and its vastness.

The Himalayas are a diverse region encompassing many diverse practices and beliefs. From the perspective of the Hindus from the plains, the Himalayan region symbolizes the ultimate ascetic experience of the renunciant—Shiva, the quintessential *yogin*, residing in the Himalayas with his wife Parvati. Both deities become transformed in local practice, taking on localized forms and histories relevant to those who are permanent residents of the Himalayas. Not surprisingly, hundreds of thousands of pilgrims travel to many different pilgrimage sites in the mountains each year.

As a reservoir of frozen water, the body and home of the God Himalaya is the divine source of sacred rivers such as the Ganges and Indus that sustain life on the hot and dusty plains of northern India. The ancient poets and sages regarded the range as more than a realm of snow; they saw it as an earthly paradise sparkling with streams and forests set beneath beautiful peaks. The Himalaya is considered a living and breathing entity in both Hindu and Buddhist philosophy. A deity in itself is deemed capable of feeling and expressing the feelings of happiness and displeasure in multiple manners.

Eastern religions including—Hinduism, Buddhism, Sikhism, and Jainism — recognize non-humans as sentient beings. In Jainism and Hinduism, this is closely related to the concept of ahimsa or nonviolence toward other beings. Right from antiquity, Indian myths and folklore have revolved a lot around nature spirits and the power bestowed on them. Various *Yaksha-Yukshi* figures seen in both Hindu, as well as Buddhist art, always

epitomize and personify an important element of nature or an important phenomenon. Rivers are often equated with a mother who nourishes and cares for her child lovingly. Various mother goddesses symbolizing the concept of fertility have been part of the visual culture for ages. The traditional Hindu thought has never erected a high wall between human existence and animal existence while recognizing the important distinctions between the two.

Lord Vishnu is believed to have incarnated ten times. He descended to the earth in ten different forms (avatars) to preserve righteousness in the world. The Himalayas have done the same: Mountains reincarnate to preserve the planet's 'right environment' for life. This Vishnu-Himalaya parallelism has mythological beauty and richness. In Hindu mythology, Himavat is the personification of the Himalayan mountains. He is the father of Ganga, a heavenly river that flew from the toe of Vishnu, but which was brought down to the earth to purify the ashes of the dead. The site where the Ganges enter the plains of northern India is called Haridwar (the gate of Hari or Shiva); in ancient times, people also called it Ganga-dwara (the gate of Ganga).

Himavat's younger daughter is variously known as Uma, Himavati, Pravati, or Devi, who is also the consort of Shiva. Nanda Devi is attributed to this goddess, while Mount Kailash is considered as Shiva's paradise and Shivling is thought to be Shiva's Lingam. Vishnu also has his foot in the Himalayas, close to the Ganges; Kedarnath and Badrinath are attributed to him in several myths. The peaks, valleys, rivers, and rocks of the Himalayas have long been perceived as a sacred landscape by its peoples, pilgrims, and scholars as well as by climbers, surveyors, and scientists.

Metaphysical Significance of a Few Himalayan Peaks on the Indian Side from Esoteric and Exoteric Perspectives

1. Nara and Narayana

As the legend goes, Sage Markandeya underwent severe penance at a shrine near the Chitra glacier on the confluence of the Ganga and Pushpa Bhadra. The Lord incarnated in the form of twin ascetics, Narayana (the first human avatar of Vishnu) and his twin brother Nara—to sage Kashyapa's son Dharma and Daksha's daughter, Matamurti—and granted him a boon that he will visualize the real form of Maya, the primeval delusive power of the Lord and thus find a way to go beyond the labyrinthine conduit of the destiny and fate of man.

This place is on the right bank of the Bhagirathi some 3.50 km west of Gomukh, the holy cow-head glacier where the Ganga becomes visible to the mortals for the first time. After the sage attained immortality (Markandeya is one of the eight immortal saints of Hinduism), the two incarnations of Lord Narayana transmuted in the form of two peaks called Nara and Narayana respectively, these are accessible from Badrinath. Nara can be seen just opposite the main temple of Badrinath, and the Narayana peak is behind the Neelkantha peak. River Alaknanda, one of the five forms of the Ganga, flows through the valley between the two peaks.

Esoterically, these denote *Jiva* and *Ishwara* which are the two reflections of the absolute principle in Maya and *avidya* (nescience and delusion). Both are the aspirant and adept aspects of a yogi and pertain to the subtler metaphysical states of consciousness.



[Nara and Narayana Ranges - Image from flickr.com]

2. Nanda Devi

It is located between the Rishiganga and Goriganga valleys in Uttarakhand. The “Goddess of Bliss” is incarnated as the daughter of Nanda and Yasoda. As she was about to be thrashed by Kamsa, the villain-uncle of Lord Krishna, she slipped off his hands and incarnated as Yogamaya, who dwells on the peak called Nanda Devi.

She is a favorite deity of many hill people who propitiate her in various ways. A mass pilgrimage takes place every twelve years, and a four-horned sheep is offered to her. She is adored as a princess who is betrothed to Lord Shiva; so, the pilgrimage is more like a bridal procession. Metaphysically speaking, Nanda is one of the six aspects of Durga which signifies the six-fold aspects of nature or *Prakriti*.



[Nanda Devi – Image from Sumod Mohan K, Wikipedia]

3. Bhrgu Tung

There is a conspicuous peak in the backdrop of the river Pushpa Bhadra which we have already mentioned as the ashram of Nara and Narayana. The river Pushpa Bhadra originates from the Chitra glacier at the base of this mountain. Self-mortification and self-extinction were the two prominent religious practices during the era of strict theocracy and ecclesiastic subservience. The practice of *Bhriguputnam* or falling from the big mountains was a popular means of salvation during the hoary past. This is also called *veeradhwa*—the path of the brave.



[Bhriugu Tung – Image from Facebook]

4. Bandarpunch (Monkey-tail)

One range of mountains between the origins of the Ganga and Yamuna looks like a massive tail of a reclining monkey. During their exile, Bhimasena was negotiating a cliff to fetch a flower of divine genus for Draupadi. He came across an old monkey who blocked his way his tail. “I am too old to move even an inch, please push it aside yourself”, said the ape.

One of the strongest men of his time, despite strenuous efforts and with all his might, Bhimasena could not move the tail even an inch. The monkey was none other than Hanumanji. Bhimasena made obeisance to the great hero and invited him to join the Pandavas in the battle of Mahabharata which was to commence shortly. “I will be there as the emblem on Arjuna’s flag and keep up your morale with constant battle cries”, said Hanumanji. Two peaks, Hanuman Tibba, a peak adjacent to the Bhriju Parvat, and Bandar Punch between Ganga and Jamuna are attributed to Hanumanji.



[Bandarpunch – Image from flickr.com]

5. Shivling

Beyond the Gangotri glacier, after crossing a few hillocks on the western side, one enters a realm of stupendous scenic beauty. A five-six km stretch of plain meadows with an immaculate crystal-clear brook flowing across it is just breathtaking and jaw-dropping! This place called *Tapovanam* has been named after a great mystic explorer of the Himalayas – Swami Tapovanamji. If the weather god is benign, one can see the mountain Shivling, a five-faced symbol of Shiva made by his nature. This peak is also visible from a few km before reaching Gomukh.

Most of the time, it is hidden by thick, dense, and dismal cloud flakes– just the way Shiviling elsewhere are often concealed under the offering of flowers, leaves, and sweetmeats.

These holy places facilitate the withdrawal of senses and the absorption of one's essential nature. Maheshwarananda, the author of *Maharthmanjari*, a *trika* mystic canon says, "The real worship of Shiva is recognizing him as one's universal self—the Lord of the universe is in no dearth of liquor, leaves or flowers".



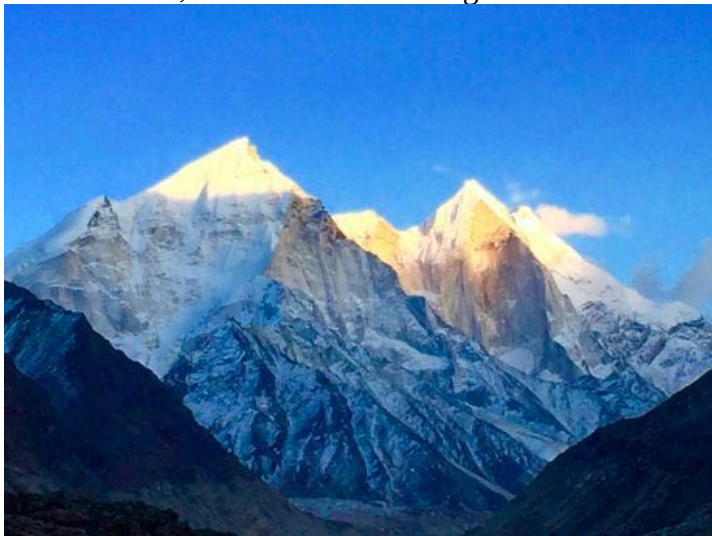
[Shivling – Image from Wikipedia]

6. Bhagirath

King Bhagiratha practiced a strenuous penance for a very long time. Unless the Ganga came down to the earth, thousands of his ancestors could not be delivered from the curse of sage Kapil.

His penance fructified. Not only did the Ganga descend but she also blessed the entire country with her austere contact till her merger into the ocean. The conspicuous peak overlooking the glacier has been named after King Bhagiratha.

Mount Bhagirath has three major peaks. The three peaks dominate the sky in the valley near Gomukh, at the end of the Gangotri Glacier.



[Bhagirath – Image from TripAdvisor]

7. Sumeru

As we climb up the glacier on the right side of the Tapovanam ridge of the Shivling, one has to walk on rough and massive boulders sometimes 10-15 m tall for a few km towards the right. Three peaks are visible, glistening in the first rays of the morning sun. Modern surveyors have given them names like Meru-1, Meru-2, and Meru-3. But, these are the three points corresponding to the three realms in the subtle world; the abode of the empress Goddess Mahatripurasundari who is believed to be residing at the middle summit of the trio ("*Sumeromadhyasringtha*"; *Lalita Sahasranama*.)

This mystic triangle, though ordinary looking, has a special mystic charm that comes either from prolonged adoration or by sharing the vision of the mystics and adepts.

These three peaks as they were, are experienced by the practitioners of kundalini yoga within their plexuses.

There is an esoteric fortification within the middle summit. The supreme divine mother dwells within a palace of the wish-fulfilling gem– *cintamani*.

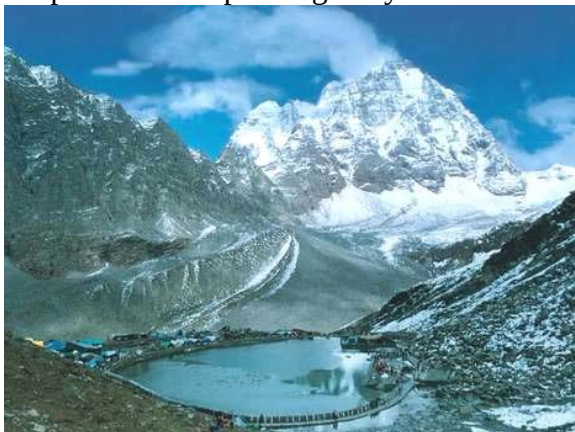
Only initiated ascetics of a very high order can experience such intricate details. For a commoner, it's just a frightening scary, chilly, and dreadful fold of the Himalayas in the middle of nowhere.



[Sumeru – Image from Quora]

8. Mani Mahesh

The Manimahesh Kailash Peak, also known as Chamba Kailash, is located in the Chamba district of Himachal Pradesh. There is Manimahesh Lake here. It is believed to be the abode of Shiva. There is a natural linga on this mountain enhancing the sanctity of the place. It also remains a virgin peak, since it has not been successfully climbed by mountaineers. The local legend goes how Manimahesh was created by Lord Shiva after his marriage with Parvati. Shiva used to show his displeasure by creating blizzards and avalanches. On lake Manimahesh's banks, Shiva performed penance. He was thence adopted as the supreme god by the local community of Gaddis.



[Mani Mahesh – Image from Amar Ujala]

9. Harmukh

Harmukh peak is located in the Ganderbal district of Jammu and Kashmir. It rises above Gangabal Lake. Harmukh means “similar on all sides”. The peak is considered the abode of Lord Shiva.



[Harmukh – Image from Wikipedia]

10. Swargarohini

Swargarohini is in the Bandarpunch Range. It consists of four separate peaks and can be seen during the Satopanth trek. Swargarohini is the main one among the four peaks. The legend mentions that the Pandavas undertook their last journey along this route. Dhaumya, the priest of the Pandavas, came to this place during their exile. Only adept yogis who are experts in pranayama can go beyond this point (*“Vana Parva”*). During the Mahabharata days, they knew about the rare oxygen but practiced pranayama (breath control) instead of carrying an oxygen cylinder on their back. After the war was over, the Pandavas resolved to walk the plank and cleanse themselves from the sin of genocide.

They took a similar route via Satopanth, literally the way to righteousness, and reached the stairway to heaven. Five boulders on the ridge are like human figures ascending the mountains. There is a general belief that they were frozen and mummified on route due to unfavorable karmas and could not make it in flesh and blood. Only Yudhishtira and his dog made it up to the summit.

In an esoteric sense, five elements viz. the earth, water, fire, air, and ether are the five Pandavas and Draupadi, their common consort, is nature. A homogeneous blend of the six leads to a perfect system that is conducive to righteousness and thus the attainment of the Kingdom of Heaven. But as the course of karma would have it, this is a rare occurrence, and only a chosen few can attain it. It was not this difficult in the eons of Satya and treta – the former pertains to the age of truth whereas the latter to the age of righteousness. Some other legends say that it is the only way to directly ascend to heaven keeping the human body intact. Therefore, this is considered as the place of immortals where the Siddhas live and guide human destiny.

Swargarohanam is a peak climbed by mountaineers from all over the world but to make it up to heaven through penance and austerities is much more difficult.



[Swargarohini - Image from eUttaranchal]

Coda

The Himalayas have been home to an intensive religious life since times immemorial. Sages, rishis, and yogis came to hidden places to meditate. Indian sacred texts and epics tell stories about miracles and revelations that happened here. Much of the Indian religious beliefs originate in the Himalayas. Each mountain, lake, and river is steeped in mythology. This “abode of the gods” includes many shrines and places of pilgrimage including the Char-Dhams—the four most sacred and revered Hindu temples: Badrinath, Kedarnath, Gangotri, and Yamunotri; Hemkund Sahib sacred to Sikhs and various gompas and monasteries deeply revered by the Buddhists.

Reaching a certain destination like Badrinath located in the lofty Himalayan heights at 10,400 feet requires one to pass from holy sites like Haridwar, Rishikesh, Devaprayag, Rudraprayag, Karna Prayag, Nanda Prayag, and Vishnuprayag which makes the entire journey a spiritual experience to be cherished for life. En-route also are Pandukeswar where the Pandavas are believed to have been born, and the site where Bhima and Hanuman (sons of Vayu) met. Hot water springs of Taptakundum are seen on the banks of the Alaknanda at Badrinath. The lofty peaks Neelakanta Parvatam and Nara Narayana Parvatam are visible from the temple Badrinath. The temple Badrinath is worshipped here in form of a *saligrama*. There is a shrine dedicated to Adi Shankara. The Kailash Mansarovar Yatra is considered the epitome of pilgrimage by both Hindus and Buddhists. The towering 22,028 ft high peak Mt. Kailash in the Himalayas, 25 miles north of the Mansarovar Lake, is hailed as the abode of Shiva. It is an arduous trek to Kailash through the snow-clad Himalayas and is attempted only by a few. The Tibetans refer to Kailash as Kang Rinpoche (Jewel of Snow).

Mount Kailash appears like a giant Shivalingam placed in a 16-petalled lotus. Pilgrims first reach Darchin, and then start their 32-mile *pradakshina* or circumambulation around the sacred mountain. From Darchin, they proceed to Landifu, then in a northeast direction to Gowrikund, 19,000 feet above sea level. Gowrikund in Tibet is known as *Thuki Singbu*. The pilgrims go further to Jandalfu and return to Darchin. There are several Buddhist temples in this area.

Mt. Kailash is regarded by the Hindu as an embodiment of Shiva and Parvati. The Buddhists refer to the sacred mountain as Kangri Karchak; they regard the presiding deity of Mt. Kailash as a Deity with three eyes, holding the *damaru* and the *trishul*; his consort is referred to as *Dorje Fangmo*. The Jains regard Mt. Kailash as the Ashtapada Mountain where the first Tirthankara Adinath (Rishabhadeva) attained nirvana.

Major rivers have their source around the Mansarovar Lake and Kailash. The Mansarovar Lake is known as *Cho Mapan*. There are two lakes here: one is the Rakshasa Tal, where Ravana is believed to have performed penances to please Shiva, and the other the Mansarovar, considered as being one of the 51 Saktipeethas,

Gangotri and Yamunotri are the sacred sites from where the two most important rivers of the north Indian plains—Ganga and Yamuna—originate. Temples dedicated to these river goddesses indicate their holiness and importance as life-giving mothers.

Every day, we see how nature is being plundered and destroyed to satisfy the insatiable hunger for more by us humans. The concern about the environment and its destruction is a much-talked-about subject these days but the world has not yet discovered the appropriate means for living in complete harmony with nature.

The universe is balanced to the very core and has a self-balancing mechanism at play. The imbalance created by humans in their lust for more will ultimately result in their own destruction. Nature punishes the follies of men—especially when they take it for granted. Many an earthquake, typhoons, and floods occur due to human negligence and carelessness towards nature. The recent tragedy at Kedarnath was an example of punishment for such a misdeed. From June 14 to 17, 2013 Uttarakhand and the adjoining areas received heavy rainfall, which was about 375% more than the benchmark rainfall during a normal monsoon. The environmental experts reported that the tunnels built, and the blasts undertaken for the 70 hydroelectric projects contributed to the ecological imbalance in the state, with flows of river water restricted and the stream-side development activity contributing to a higher number of landslides and more flooding.

Similarly, the recent floods in Jammu and Kashmir were attributed to unlawful occupation and filling up of the flood channels which resulted in floodwaters getting collected in the city and hence drowning major areas.

Worshipping and respecting nature is in no way a superstition, but it is a constant reminder that we are dependent on nature for everything, and we should do nothing to invoke its wrath.

The ancient Rishis and seers of India lived in the caves of the Himalayas did rigorous penance. The temperature is quite even in a cave, and they are generally cool in summers. The heat of the scorching summer cannot penetrate inside the cave. It is quite warm in winter. All external sounds are shut out in a cave so one can engage in uninterrupted meditation. There is solitude in caves and the spiritual currents are elevating. The Himalayas is full of natural as well as manmade caves primarily for meditation. The Buddhist rock-cut caves which serve as both chaityagrihas and viharas were quite popular in this region especially in Ladakh, Tibet, and Spiti. Manmade caves were created for monks who needed solace and an austere atmosphere to carry out their meditational and devotional activities. Such caves were often carved away from human habitation.

It is the abundance of natural caves in the area along with the flowing river which lends the special status as a spiritual haven to this region. So many saints have been known to have achieved God-consciousness in one of these natural caverns. There are many yogis still meditating in the caves of the Himalayas. They are isolated from the modern world. They have the power to resist the extreme weather conditions of the Himalayas.

The Himalayas have three unparalleled qualities, which is amazing. Firstly, there is solitude; the environment is pristine and spiritually vibrant. Secondly, there is eternal silence, eternal concentration, and the light of energy (Shakti) flowing here. That is why mountain peaks, snow-covered areas, and such places are considered holy. Many *sadhakas* have not even seen such areas of the Himalayas where *Siddhas* have made their home, which has mystical and secret doorways through which one can gain entry to the Maha-Himalaya—the subtle astral realm superimposed on the gross physical dimension. Almost all avatars, *Siddhas*, *maha yogis* who have achieved any heights in the field of spirituality have talked about it. There is this physical expanse of mountains in the Himalayas which can be seen through the eyes and felt ordinarily—the visible Himalaya. But there is another invisible Himalaya above this visible Himalaya. This is the third quality. And across all yugas, this invisible Maha-Himalaya has sent its messengers, its representatives to the known world, carrying the message of Truth. Death is not the end of life, rather there is another amazing life after death. And in fact, one can gain access to that astral life usually accessible after death, even while being alive. And that is the *sadhaka's* life—a spiritual life.

[An article published in a book titled Himalayan Bridge]

Harihara-abheda in the Light of Madhusudana Saraswati's Commentary on Shivamahimnah Stotra

(co-authored by Prof. Satheesha K.S., National Sanskrit University, Tirupathi and Sri Shankararama Sharma R, Ph.D. Scholar, IISc, Bangalore)

The Stotra literature derives its inspiration from the Vedas and encompasses a vast field. Some of these Stotras are considered as *Stotra Kāvya*s i.e poems in the form of hymns. *Śivamahimna-stotra* – one of the earliest Stotra kāvyas attained a special status among the Stotras. Its grandeur and depth continue to be a source of mesmerisation for the devotees of Lord Śiva. The hymns are considered to have mystical powers and the Stotra is considered as Mantratmaka – an embodiment of divine syllables. Like Saundarya Lahari of Ādi Śaṅkara, this Stotra possesses the status of a hymn, Stotra, and poetry (Kāvya). *Puṣpadanta*, a celestial being is attributed to be the author of this Stotra, and the legends therein are passed down hereditarily. The other Mahimana-stotras derive their inspiration from this particular stotra and we have so many stotras like Saktimahimna-stotra, Gaṇeśa mahimna-stotra, etc.

Madhusūdana Sarasvatī, an authentic exponent of Advaita Vedānta was the disciple of Srirama, Vishweshwara, and Madhava according to his Mangala shloka in his Advaita Siddhi. He was a great devotee of Lord Kṛṣṇa. Apart from his various texts in Advaita, Mimamsa, and other shastras, he wrote a commentary for this great shiva mahimna Stotra kāvya. He interpreted the verses in such a way as to fit Hara (Siva) and Hari (Kṛṣṇa), thus establishing the *Hari-Harābheda* which espouses the Advaitic standpoint. The poetry has a lucid style and it attracts the readers with all its eloquence. We shall see a couple of examples:

**महिम्नः पारं ते परम-विदुषो यद्यसदृशी
स्तुतिर्ब्रह्मादीनामपि तदवसन्नास्त्वयि गिरः ।
अथाऽवाच्यः सर्वः स्वमतिपरिणामावधि गृणन्
ममाप्येष स्तोत्रे (अ)हर निरपवादः परिकरः ॥ १॥**

O, Lord Hara/Ahara, what wonder is there, if the prayer to you, chanted by one who is ignorant about your greatness, is worthless! Because even the utterance (speech) of Brahma and other gods is not able to fathom your Mahima. Hence, if persons with very limited intellect (and I am one of them) try to offer you a prayer, their attempt deserves your special favour. If it is so, I should not be an exception. Hence, (thinking like this) I begin this prayer. (Translation from sanskritdocuments.org)

The poet addresses Bhagavan as ‘Hara’. This is a well-known epithet of Siva. One who removes all sorrows is called ‘Hara’. The same word in the shloka can also be split as ‘Ahara’. When read this way, it refers to Hari. One who does not remove is ‘Ahara’, i.e. one who protects. Or the word ‘Parama’ could also refer to Hari. Here it means Lakshmi-pati (परा मा लक्ष्मीः यस्य). The rest of the shloka has a similar meaning whether seen from the perspective of Hara or Hari.

**मधुस्फीता वाचः परमममृतं निर्मितवतः
तव ब्रह्मन् किं वागपि सुरगुरोर्विस्मयपदम् ।
मम त्वेतां वाणीं गुणकथनपुण्येन भवतः
पुनामीत्यर्थऽस्मिन् पुरमथन बुद्धिर्व्यवसिता ॥ ३ ॥**

O, Paramatma (Greatest Soul), as you are the very creator of the speech of the Vedas, which is like the highest type of nectar and as sweet as honey, how can even the speech of Brihaspati (Guru, or spiritual guide of gods) surprise you? (i.e., the speech of even Brihaspati is worthless before you). O, Puramathana, thinking that my speech may become purified by this act, my intellect (Buddhi) has become prepared to sing your greatness.

In this verse, the word ‘Puramathana’ is used to address Bhagavan. While addressing Siva it is interpreted as the destroyer of the three cities (Tripura). When addressing Visnu, it can be interpreted as the person whose place is Gokula (a place where Mathana-churning happens) or a person who resides in the ocean of Milk (the place where Amruta was churned from Milk). The rest of the verse applies to both Hari and Hara.

In this way, Madhusudana Saraswati interprets all the verses of the Stotra for both Hari and Hara.

Similar efforts

There are other scholars and poets also who have attempted this idea of Hari-Hara abheda. For instance, another stalwart of the Advaitic tradition, **Sri Appaya Dikshita** has also composed a beautiful verse that intertwines Hari and Hara.

मारमणम् उमारमणं फणधरतल्पं फणाधराकल्पम्।
मुरमथनं पुरमथनं वन्दे बाणारिम् असमबाणारिम्॥

I bow to the consort of Mā (Lakshmi), the consort of Umā; the one with a snake-bed and the one with snake ornaments; the one who defeated Mura and the one who defeated Pura (Tripura), the enemy of Bāṇāsura (Lord Krishna) and the enemy of the one with an odd number of arrows (Manmatha, who has five arrows).

Sridhara Ayyaval was a saintly Grihastha who expounded the greatness of Siva Nama. In his work called ‘Aakhyaashashtih’, which personifies the name of the lord itself he says:

शिवाख्ये वाच्योऽर्थस्तव हि पुरभिद्वाऽस्तु मुरभित्
स लोकानामीष्टाम् अवतु च सुखेन श्रितजनम् ।
अलं नाहं तस्यानुसृतिषु स मा भूदपि च मे
श्रितोऽहं त्वां यत्त्वद्भवति मम कल्याणि तदलम् ॥

O Name, Let the meaning conveyed by you be Shiva (Purabhit) or Vishnu (Murabhit). Let the God so meant, either be lord over the worlds or protect with happiness those that resort to him; I am not equal to (the task of) propitiating that god; why, let him never be for me; O Auspicious Name! I have sought you and what comes from you suffices for me.

Social impacts

Apart from developing harmony between rivaling Shaivas and Vaishnavas, these kinds of attempts may be the inspiration behind the worship of the deity Shankara-Narayana, a combined deity form of Shiva (Shankara) on the right with Nandi and Vishnu (Narayana) on the left with Garuda.

There are two famous temples for Shankaranarayana in the south. One is situated in Shankaranarayana village, named after the temple, which is located in the valley of mountain ranges close to the Sahyadris. It is in the Udupi District of Karnataka. The main deity here is in the form of Udbhava Linga. The naturally formed lingam of Lord Shankara and Lord Narayana is one foot below the ground, inside the Garbhagruha. The devotees

can only see the image of the lingam in a mirror through reflection. The Shankara Linga is on the right (left as seen by the devotees) and Narayana Linga on the left. While Shankara Lingam is in round shape, the Narayana Linga is flat, with footprints of a cow in it. Devotees believe that these were the footprints of Kamadhenu (divine cow) which had stood there for dripping milk on the Shankara Linga. There is water around Udbhaav Linga all through the year. This holy water is called Suddhamrita Theertha. Koti theertha is located in front of the temple. Devotees coming to this temple first make a prokshana of this theertha and then proceed for the darshan of Lord Shankaranarayana. The stone enclosure and the surrounding coconut and areca nut groves enhance the beauty of the pond. The pond has a rich spiritual bearing. Rituals such as Pitru tarpana and Theerthasnanam are held at this pond. Koti theertha stands out as the most beautiful and vast of all the twenty-one ponds found around this place.



The second is situated at Sankarankoil in Tirunelveli district of Tamil Nadu. It was built by Ukkira Pandiyan around 900 CE. The deities of this temple are Sri Sankareswarar, Sri

Gomathi
Narayana.

Amman,

and

Sri

Sankara-



The general belief is that the Holy Sand “Puttrumann” (Puttru = Ant Hill, Mann = Sand) that one gets from this temple is capable of curing all the diseases. Devotees believe that *Sankarankovil’s Nagasunai* (sacred tank) has been dug by serpent kings named *Paduman* and *Sangam*, which has a miraculous power to heal those who bathe there. The temple poses as an example of marvelous architecture in that, the sunrays at dawn enter the sanctum sanctorum of Lord Sankaralinga Swamy on the days of equinox viz. 21st, 22nd, and 23rd days of March and September every year. This temple is the chief among the Panchaboortha Sthalas of South, the five places each of which represents one of the five elements. The element typified here is Earth.

Names like *Sankaranarayana*, *Shankararama*, *Ramasubrahmanya*, etc. are widely prevalent in southern parts of India. All these indicate the Hari-Hara-Abheda and ‘Unity in Diversity’.

This is also presented by **Sri Papanasam Sivan** in his Carnatic Kriti, ‘*Ma Ramanan Uma Ramanan*’ (<https://www.karnatik.com/c1343.shtml>), set to Raga Hindolam where he sings about Shankara and Narayana in the same song.

Conclusion

This beautiful verse provides an apt curtain to our exploration of HariHara-Abheda. Each adjective in the below shloka refers to Shiva when read as is, and refers to Vishnu when we remove the first letter.

पायात् कुमारजनकः शशिखण्ड-मौलिः शङ्खप्रभश्च निधनश्च गवीशयानः ।

गङ्गाञ्च पन्नगधरश्च उमाविलासः आद्यक्षरेण सहितो रहितोऽपि देवः ॥

Kumarajanakah – father of Subrahmanya, Marajanakah – father of Manmatha (Pradyumna)

Shashikhanda-Moulih – one with the crescent moon, Shikhanda-Moulih – one with the peacock feather on his head

Shankhaprabhah – one with the hue of the conch, Khaprabhah – one who has the colour of the sky

Gaveeshayanah – one whose vehicle is the lord of bulls (Nandi), Veeshayanah – one whose vehicle is the Lord of birds (Garuda)

Gangaam – the river, Gaam – cow

Pannagadharah – who is ornamented by snakes, Nagadharah – who carries the mountain (Govardhana/Mandara)

Umavilasah – who pleases Uma(Parvati), Maavilasah – who pleases Ma (Lakshmi)

May this god protect us along and without the first letter.

Let us all prostrate before the almighty who appears in the form of Shankara and Narayana and blesses devotees according to their Manobhava.

The Three Bodies in Yoga

[Bhoomi Sati]

Our bodies, according to yoga philosophy, are truly made up of three bodies: physical, astral, and causal. The physical body is the skin and bones that make us up. Our astral bodies are the means by which we experience bliss or suffering. It has something to do with our senses. Our pattern for the gross and subtle bodies is the causal body, also known as the seed body. It's a body that's far more difficult to detect, and one with which we frequently lose touch. It connects us to our larger selves. It stores all our previous experiences, memories, habits, and information from all our previous incarnations. Both the astral and causal bodies vacate the physical body at the same time when one dies. There are five sheaths or 'koshas' within these three bodies: *annamaya kosha* (the food sheath), *pranamaya kosha* (the vital sheath), *manomaya kosha* (the mental sheath), *vijnanamaya kosha* (the intellectual sheath), and *anandamaya kosha* (the bliss sheath). The multiple energetic layers that make up a human being beyond physicality are referred to as the subtle body. It is made up of three of the five koshas (sheaths) that make up human existence, i.e., the *pranamaya kosha*, *manomaya kosha*, and the *vijnanamaya kosha*. All three bodies are interrelated, and maximum functioning happens when they work together in harmony. Each of the three bodies contributes to the Self's journey toward moksha, or liberation from the cycle of birth and death. Yoga's goal is to bring these three bodies' energies together, starting with the physical, then the astral, and finally the causal.

The Gross Body

The gross body, also known as *Sthula sarira*, is the material bodily mortal body that eats, breathes, and moves (acts). It is made up of a variety of elements that have undergone panchikarana, or the combination of the five primordial subtle elements, as a result of one's karmas (actions) in a previous existence. We are made up of our skin and bones, and that is the gross body. Earth (prithivi), water (apas), fire (Agni), air (Vayu), and ether are the five elements that make up our physical bodies (akasha). Our asana practice can help us to balance or heighten these elements. Leg lifts and headstands can help to develop Agni (fire) in the abdomen. Deep breathing might help us balance the Vayu (air) in our postures. Grounding poses like warriors or tree poses might help us feel more connected to the soil.

The five elements make up this gross body, as previously stated. The way and proportion in which they combine is governed by the person's previous life. The gross body that results in experiences pleasure and suffering in proportion. Only the omniscient Lord can distribute the fruits, and only in accordance with one's previous actions. Man connects himself with the gross body and succumbs to sense attractions due to his innate nescience. Only in the waking state does one experience all physiological pleasures and sufferings. This is because the inner divine presence enlivens the sense organs. The sense organs stop working throughout the dream and dreamless sleep stages. The inner divinity is the lone witness to all three states. As a result, man's physical body is his only means of communication with the outside world. The inner consciousness, which takes on various functions, is explained clearly using the analogies of the same gold that takes on various forms such as a bangle, ring, chain, and so on, and the same water that takes on various forms such as a river, lake, tank, and so on, depending on its appearance.

The gross body is the *Jiva's* experience instrument, which is attached to the body and ruled by Ahamkara and uses the body's external and interior sense and action organs. In its waking state, the Jiva, identifying with the body, appreciates gross items. Man's contact with the outside world hinges on his body. *Sambhava* (birth), *Jara* (old age or aging), *Maranam* (death), and the "Waking State" are the key aspects of the *Sthula sarira*.

The Subtle Body

The Subtle Body, or *Sukshma Sharira*, according to the Bhagavad Gita, is characterized as a combination of the mind, intellect, and ego, and it is the subtle body that controls the physical bodily functions. The yogi senses pleasure and pain through the subtle body. The subtle body is depicted as emanating from the causal body and manifesting and governing all elements of the physical body in ancient Indian literature such as the Upanishads and the Bhagavad Gita. The subtle body is thought to transmigrate after physical death, acting as a conduit for rebirth.

The Brhadaranyaka Upanishad and the Katha Upanishad are two Upanishads that contain early conceptions of the subtle body. The principle of five koshas or sheaths is described in the Taittiriya Upanishad, albeit these are not to be conceived of as concentric layers, but rather as interpenetrating at increasing levels of subtlety:

The anna-maya ("food body", physical body, the grossest level),
The prana-maya (body made of vital breath or prana),
The mano-maya (body made of mind),
The vijñana-maya (body made of consciousness)
The ananda-maya is a state of joy (bliss body, the subtlest level).

The idea of a subtle body is essential to Yogic, Tantric, and Taoist traditions, as well as various Hindu and Buddhist schools. Subtle body awareness can be established through the third eye, even though it cannot be seen with the physical eye. Each layer of the subtle body, as it moves outwards from the physical body, is supposed to vibrate at a quicker pace than the one before it. It becomes possible to manipulate the energies of the physical and subtle bodies as a means of connecting with the higher Self through the causal body through yoga techniques such as asana, pranayama, and meditation.

Prana (vital life force energy) passes through the subtle body along routes known as *nadis*, which merge at energy centers known as chakras, according to the Yogic system. Any obstruction or imbalance in this system can result in physical and emotional discomfort, as well as illness and disease. The subtle body paradigm is employed as a map of central nervous system function in traditional Indian and Tibetan medicine.

The subtle body has its roots in multiple schools of thought including Buddhism, Hinduism, Taoist traditions, etc. Even though it has its roots in ancient history, western scientists have begun to investigate the concept of the subtle body in relation to meditation research. The subtle body model can be cross-referenced with modern central nervous system maps and used in meditation research.

The Causal Body

The causal body is also called *Karana sharira* in Sanskrit. It is made up of karma and samskara, which are the yogi's acts in all states of existence and the mind's experiencing perceptions and imprints, respectively. The causal body is one of three bodies in yogic philosophy that contain each individual's soul, the others being the physical and astral bodies. The causal body is the most subtle of the three, and it is encased in the other two. The body is responsible for transporting the individual's essence from one life to the next. The causal body, also known as the *karana sarira*, is simply the cause or seed of the subtle and gross bodies. It serves no other purpose than to be the seed of the subtle and gross bodies. It's called *nirvikalpa rupam*, which means "undifferentiated shape." It begins with avidya, or "ignorance" or "nescience" of the atman's true identity, giving rise to the concept of jiva.

The causal body is one's core functioning and is the core of one's existence. The causal body is made up of the sensory experience's root or seed potential. The tanmatras are what they're called. It also contains *ahamkara* (feeling of separateness), which is used to build

physical and subtle bodies. Furthermore, there is a higher component of our mind that supervises the seed's development. This is the highest form of our buddhi (intellect). In this form, buddhi is linked to the universal intelligence known as *mahat* in Sankhya philosophy, rather than the senses or the soul. When we die, our causal body follows us from lifetime to lifetime, carrying with it our karmic records. The karmic body, in a sense, never dies since it was never truly alive, to begin with. It's a karma-sustained seed. When a person's karma is spent, their individual awareness is released to blend back into the ocean of pure consciousness.

The latter two of Patanjali's Eight Limbs of Yoga, dhyana (meditation or concentration) and samadhi (meditation or concentration), connect a yogi with the causal body (super consciousness or bliss). Individuality exists to a limited extent in the causal body. When a yogi quits associating with his or her lower self's wants and needs, the higher Self and truth can emerge.

The causal body is thought to be the most complicated of the three. It comprises the impressions of experience gleaned from previous encounters. We get to know God through the causal body. We experience our greatest connection to something which is larger than our individual selves through this body.

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Pratyabhijna Made Easy

9th aphorism

तद्भूमिकाः सर्वदर्शनस्थितयः।

Tad Bhoomika Sarva Darshan Sithithyah

Translation: All philosophical standpoints of various doctrines are the roles played/assumed by the supreme self.

Exposition:

Sarvadarsan: There are 5 atheistic and 6 theistic doctrines i.e., eleven philosophies which propound the physical gross self, prana, sense organs, mind, intellect, and the supreme bliss as the essential nature respectively. According to Pratyabhijna philosophy, it is the supreme self itself who plays an atheist as well as a theist. To substantiate this, they suggest that even an obscurantist, determinist, or sceptic who denies Parmashiva as their essential nature cannot do so without the all-pervasive consciousness as their self like one cannot say 'I have no tongue in my mouth without having a tongue.'

Sarvadarsan invariably includes the vast spectrum of all metaphysical doctrines which are arranged along the various peripheries of the Shri Chakra, the mystic configuration of the projections of the power of consciousness described in the 20th sutra.

1. The three-atheist philosophy - In the outermost three peripheries
 - i) Charvaka
 - ii) Laokayatika and
 - iii) Barhaspatya
2. Smart and Puranas itihasa - Three rings between the outermost periphery and the sixteen petaled lotus.
3. Buddhist philosophy - Seated in the eight-petal lotus.
4. Sankhya yoga and vaisesika - Seated in the fourteen spokes periphery.
5. Karma meemansa or pure meemansa - Outer ten spokes - rites and the ritualistic ascent of the vedas.
6. Brahma meemansa or uttarmeemansa - The inner ten spokes.
7. Vaishnav philosophy in the eight-spoked periphery outsmarting the innermost triangle.
8. Shakta philosophy in the innermost triangle - Shiva philosophy in the bindu or point.
9. Shambhava philosophy in the fifteen syllable Shrividya lying above the bindu.

All theistic and atheistic philosophies are included in these 6 philosophies. The presiding deities of these philosophies are various manifestations of the primeval consciousness who virtually enact these various roles as it were to suit the competence and objectives of various gradations of aspirants

Bhoomika: Literally the term means various roles played by an actor on the stage. Similarly, various philosophical standpoints and their essence are roles Paramshiva assumes of his own will and like an actor who is always conscious of his/her actual identity though on the stage he/she might have got into the skin of the character, the essential nature is ever pervading.

Khemendra the commentator of Pratyabhijna Hridayam gives a slightly different description of the above-mentioned configuration which is as below.

These various actors (doctrines) propound the different states as the essential nature respectively:

1. Charvakas consider the gross physical body as the self.
2. For Nyaya and Vaishesika sentences is the self and after dissolution, only void remains.
3. Jains are limited to the power of Bhutas.
4. Buddhists are confined to Buddhi tatva.
5. Knowers of Vedas are confined to the Purusha element.
6. Meemamsakas are also confined to the realm of intellect since they opine that the notion of 'meem' is conditioned and concealed in the attributes like pleasure, pain etc. The continuity of the streamline of consciousness is the ultimate, so in a way they are also confined to the realm of intelligence.
7. Some of the Vedantists maintain that spirit or prana is the self (Tatvakar branch of Samveda). Vedantists who include abhava or absence as the sixth testimony or evidence are confined to void. Some Madhyamika also opine with the above doctrine.
8. Vaisnavites (followers of Panchratra Tantra) believe in Jiva as comparable to sparks from the fire i.e., parts of the main Lord Vasudeva.
9. According to Agamic ontology all Sankhya etc., (including Vaishesikas) are situated in Vijnankal realm.
10. Followers of Upanisadic monism are limited to Isvara tatva since they assert that only existence prevailed in the beginning so for the existence and non-existence are the main notions.
11. All grammarians (purists) are limited to Sadashiva tatva since they maintain that shabdbrahma (God as the primordial word) which dawns upon in the Pashyanti mode of Vak is the essential nature.
12. Tantriks believe that the self pervades the universal phenomena.
13. For Kaulas it transcends universal phenomena.
14. Trika, Ishwaradvaita and Pratyabhijna opine that it both pervades and transcends the universe in Vishvotirna and Vishvatmak forms. The belief persists that human effort alone cannot go beyond the stage of buddhi because this tatva responsible for discerning, understanding and discriminating, lacks the agency to explain what is beyond it and what has been hidden from it by the panch kanchukas. One would be unable to go beyond this point unless grace (anugraha) dawns on him/her. All one can do is to pray for grace and meanwhile orient the senses and control them.

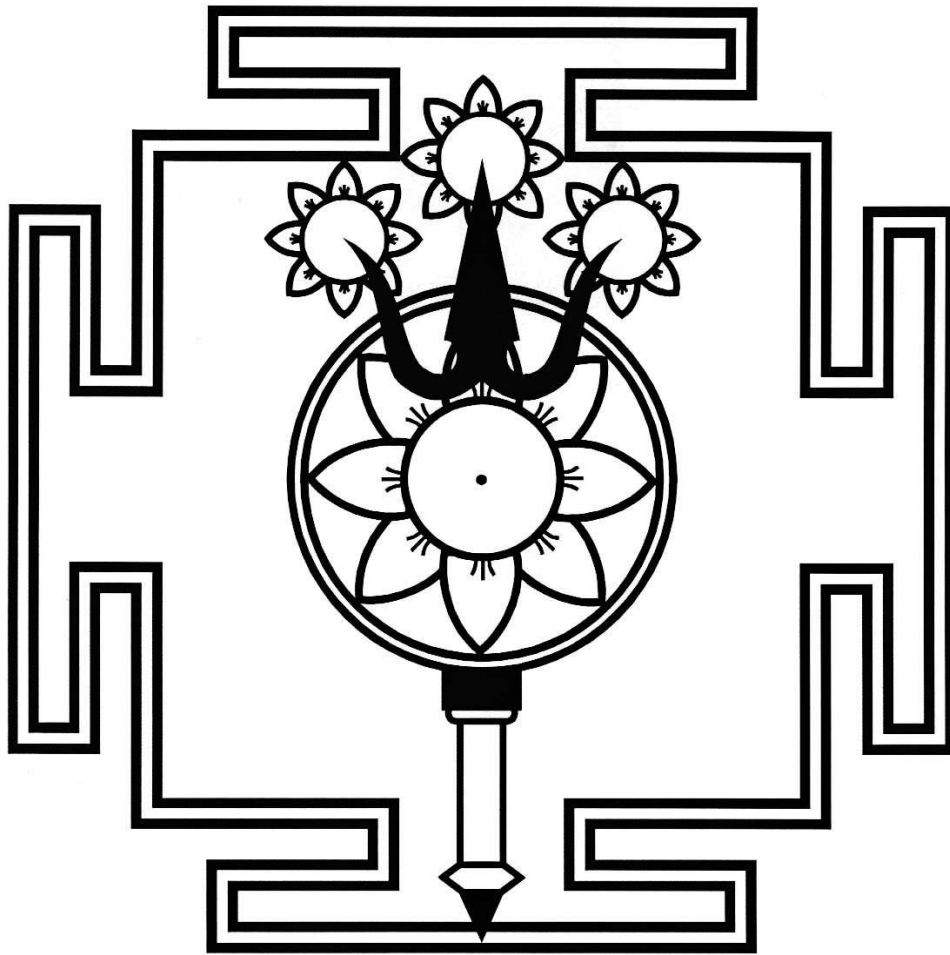
The long and short of all this is to bring home the fact that no doctrine is sufficient to propound the essential nature, independently so all of these have to be integrated and oriented so that beginning from a 'pashu' up to an aspirant of highest competence are redeemed.

From the YTA classroom.

6**Poem**

Where flowers wander cells love
it when we smile even if worlds
break nothing matters but the great
empty from which all comes chalice is
passages for the flow of the
fountain always traveller longs for the
great empty flowers grow there.

[Ambika Talwar. The poetess is a professor of creative arts in the US]



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